

Revolution in Haiti

In the 18th century, Haiti was a colony of France known as Saint-Domingue. In 1791, thousands of enslaved people rose up in rebellion against French colonists, an event that forced the French to abolish enslavement across their empire. In 1804, Saint-Domingue declared its independence from France and became the world's first Black-governed republic.

France had established its colony of Saint-Domingue on the Caribbean island of Hispaniola in 1659. Soon, plantations were set up across the colony and enslaved Africans were shipped across the Atlantic to work on them. By the 1780s, Saint-Domingue was the top producer of sugar and coffee in the world.

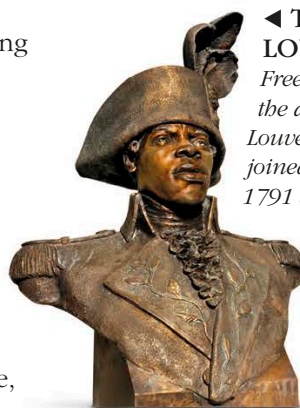
After the French Revolution in 1789, revolutionaries in France granted free people of color (*affranchis*) French citizenship, but when white plantation

owners refused to accept this, fighting broke out. By 1791, thousands of enslaved people had joined the revolt. They found an inspirational leader in Toussaint Louverture, who created a powerful army and gradually took over the island. Saint-Domingue's declaration of independence from France in 1804 inspired others to resist colonial rule, as they learned how the formerly enslaved had liberated themselves.



▲ BURNING PLANTATIONS

During the revolution in Haiti, enslaved workers burned the plantations they were forced to work on to the ground and killed their French enslavers. Within three years, France was forced to end enslavement in all its colonies.



◀ TOUSSAINT LOUVERTURE

Freed from slavery at the age of 33, Toussaint Louverture (c. 1743–1803) joined the rebellion in 1791 and transformed it into a revolutionary force. His brilliant leadership paved the way for Haiti to become an independent country.



AFFRANCHIS

During their rule, French colonists in Saint-Domingue created a class system, with white elites at the top, affranchis in the middle, and enslaved Africans at the bottom. Affranchis were free people of color or mixed race people who had some legal rights.

TAKE A LOOK

The Vodou religion is derived from West African beliefs, such as those of the Fon people, mixed with Roman Catholicism. It played an important role during the revolution. Enslaved Africans came together at secret Vodou gatherings, and the religion became a symbol of resistance against French rule. Vodou is still an important part of life in Haiti today.

